

Chapter 19

The Baroque in Italy and Spain

Learning Objectives

1. Understand the characteristics of the Baroque style.
2. Consider how Baroque religious architecture in Rome reflects the values of the Counter-Reformation.
3. Investigate the evolution of ceiling painting.
4. Evaluate the Baroque concept of the “unification” of the arts.
5. Consider the qualities and innovations of Spanish seventeenth-century art.



Gianlorenzo Bernini ST. TERESA OF ÁVILA IN ECSTASY
Cornaro Chapel, church of Santa Maria della Vittoria, Rome. 1645–1652.
Marble, height of the group 11'6" (3.5 m).
© 2016. Photo Scala, Florence/Fondo Edifici di Culto – Min. dell'Interno.

"Baroque" (1 of 2)

- As rulers' economic strength slipped away, artists found patrons in the Church and prosperous middle class.
- Baroque art was meant to evoke intense emotional responses from viewers.
- Many artists sought lifelike depiction in their portraiture, **genre paintings**, still life, and religious scenes.

"Baroque" (2 of 2)

- The role of viewer changed in the time of the seventeenth century.
 - Masters sought to engage viewers as participants in the artwork, reaching beyond the frame.



SEVENTEENTH-CENTURY EUROPE

Protestantism still dominated northern Europe, while in the south Roman Catholicism remained strong after the Counter-Reformation. The Habsburg empire was now divided into two parts, under separate rulers.

Italy

- Seventeenth-century Italy remained divided.
- Art was used to inspire the revitalization of the Roman Catholic Church.
 - Guidelines set by the Council of Trent went against the lascivious trends exploited by Mannerism.

Maderno and Bernini at St. Peter's

(1 of 3)

- The Counter-Reformation sought to embellish the church and its settings properly.
- Pope Sixtus ordered open spaces to be cleared in front of major churches in Rome.
- Building programs nearly bankrupted the Church.

Maderno and Bernini at St. Peter's

(2 of 3)

- Bernini supervised the design and building of a colonnade to enclose the double piazza in front of the church, which already contained an Egyptian obelisk and a fountain.
 - He characterized the design as the "motherly arms of the church."



Carlo Maderno and Gianlorenzo Bernini ST. PETER'S BASILICA AND PIAZZA,
VATICAN, ROME
Maderno, façade, 1607–1626; Bernini, piazza design, c. 1656–1657.
© Alinari Archives/Corbis.

Maderno and Bernini at St. Peter's

(3 of 3)

- Pope Urban VIII gave Bernini the task of designing the bronze baldacchino (canopy) over the altar of St. Peter's.
- He chose a form of winding grapevines to encircle copies of columns from Solomon's Temple in Jerusalem.
- Emblems of honeybees, suns, and laurel leaves—signifying the Barberini family—are also prominent in the design.



Gianlorenzo Bernini BALDACCHINO

St. Peter's Basilica, Vatican, Rome. 1624–1633.

Gilt bronze, height approx. 100' (30.48 m). Chair of Peter shrine, 1657–1666; gilt bronze, marble, stucco, and glass.
Pier decorations, 1627–1641; gilt bronze and marble. © akg-images/Bildarchiv Monheim.

Bernini as Sculptor (1 of 2)

- Bernini's statue of *David* introduced a new type of three-dimensional composition that interacts with the space around the viewer.



Gianlorenzo Bernini DAVID
1623. Marble, height 5'7" (1.7 m).

Galleria Borghese, Rome. © Per concessione del Ministero per i Beni e le Attività Culturali/Archivi Alinari, Firenze.

Bernini as Sculptor (2 of 2)

- Bernini was later commissioned to create the sculptural tableau *St. Teresa of Ávila in Ecstasy* for the funeral chapel of cardinal Federigo Cornaro.
- The complex, theatrical interplay dissolves into the painting above.



Gianlorenzo Bernini CORNARO CHAPEL, CHURCH OF SANTA MARIA DELLA VITTORIA, ROME
1642–1652.
© Vincenzo Pirozzi, Rome.

Borromini (1 of 2)

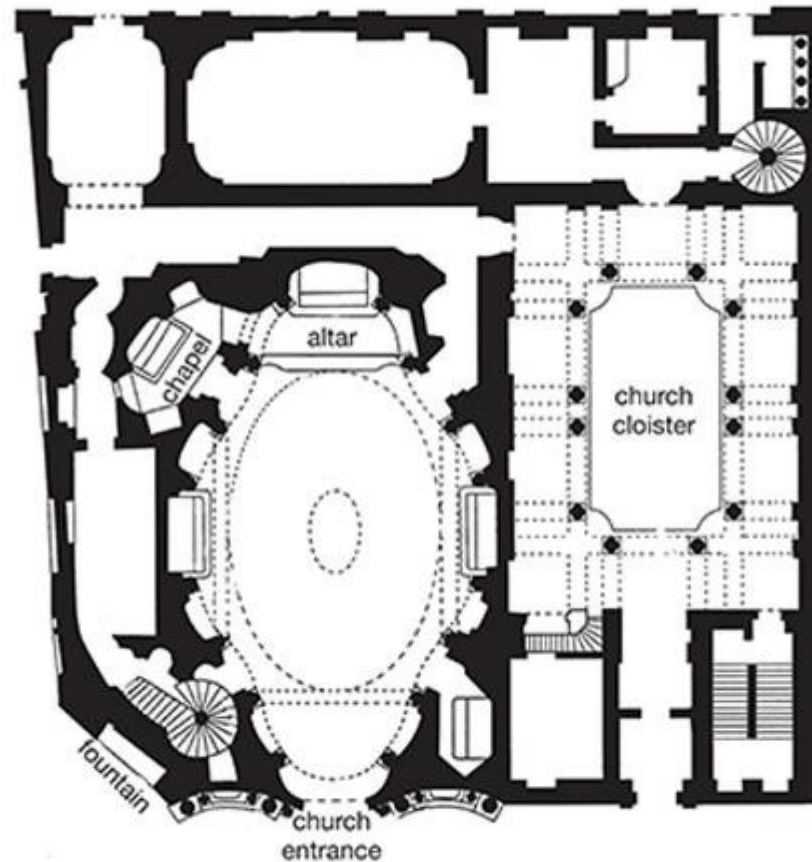
- Church of San Carlo
 - Francesco Borromini (1599–1667) designed the Church of San Carlo alle Quattro Fontane on an irregular plot at an intersection.
 - The interior space is marked with an oval dome, a honeycomb of crosses and polygons, and a geometric approach instead of a traditional one.

Borromini (2 of 2)

- Church of San Carlo
 - The façade of the church is filled with sculpture, including a forward-leaning cartouche held up by high-relief angels.



Francesco Borromini FAÇADE OF THE CHURCH OF SAN CARLO ALLE QUATTRO FONTANE
Rome. 1638–1667.
© 2016. Photo Scala, Florence.



Francesco Borromini PLAN OF THE CHURCH OF SAN CARLO ALLE QUATTRO FONTANE
Rome. 1638–1667.



Francesco Borromini VIEW INTO THE DOME OF THE CHURCH OF SAN CARLO ALLE QUATTRO FONTANE
Rome. 1638–1667.
© View Pictures Ltd/Alamy Stock Photo.

Painting (1 of 9)

- The ordered Classicism of the Caracci rejected the artifice of the Mannerist style and focused on line, compositional structure, and figural solidity.
- The dramatic naturalism of Caravaggio, in contrast, developed powerful realism with subjects as gritty as the lowlife of Rome.

Painting (2 of 9)

- The Carracci
 - Brothers Agostino and Annibale with their cousin Ludovico re-evaluated High Renaissance masters.
 - Annibale was hired to decorate principal rooms in Cardinal Odoardo Farnese's palace.
 - Complex figural scenes are based on Ovid's *Metamorphoses*.



Annibale Carracci CEILING OF GALLERY, PALAZZO FARNESE
Rome. 1597–1601.
Fresco, approx. 68' × 21' (20.7 × 6.4 m).
Canali Photobank, Milan, Italy.

Painting (3 of 9)

- Caravaggio
 - The subjects of Caravaggio (1571–1610) in the 1590s include still lifes and scenes of young men dressed as mythological figures.
 - *Bacchus* may represent an erotic invitation or an actor in the role of the god of wine, an ambiguity made more striking by the juxtaposition with rotting fruit.



Caravaggio BACCHUS
1595–1596. Oil on canvas, 37 × 33-1/2" (94 × 85.1 cm).
Galleria degli Uffizi, Florence. © Quattrone, Florence.

Painting (4 of 9)

- Caravaggio
 - The technique created by Caravaggio known as **tenebrism** involved figures emerging from a dark background into a strong light that falls from a single source, like a theatrical spotlight.

Painting (5 of 9)

- Caravaggio
 - Caravaggio's commissions after 1600 were for religious art.
 - In the Contarelli Chapel, three large oil paintings on the subject of St. Matthew were produced in a studio instead of directly applied to the wall in fresco.
 - *The Calling of St. Matthew* features particularly stark contrast between the dark interior and the spotlight on the surprised saint.



CONTARELLI CHAPEL, SAN LUIGI DEI FRANCESI
Rome. Paintings by Caravaggio 1599–1600.
© 2016. Photo Scala, Florence.



Caravaggio THE CALLING OF ST. MATTHEW
Contarelli Chapel, church of San Luigi dei Francesi, Rome. 1599–1600.
Oil on canvas, 10'7-1/2" × 11'2" (3.24 × 3.4 m).
© Quattrone, Florence.

Painting (6 of 9)

- Caravaggio
 - *The Conversion of St. Paul* is a painting with no physical setting that focuses on Paul's internal movement.
 - The horse takes up more space than the saint, causing more tension.
 - The artist's temper got him into trouble, eventually leading to his killing a man over a disputed tennis match.



Caravaggio THE CONVERSION OF ST. PAUL
Cerasi Chapel, Santa Maria del Popolo, Rome. c. 1601.
Oil on canvas, 7'6" × 5'8" (2.3 × 1.75 m).
© Vincenzo Pirozzi, Rome.

Painting (7 of 9)

- Artemisia Gentileschi
 - She helped spread the Caravaggesque style beyond Rome, first studying under her father.
 - *Judith Beheading Holofernes* draws its subject from the book of Judith.
 - The heroic act is emphasized by gory details such as blood spurting wildly from the victim's neck.



Artemisia Gentileschi JUDITH BEHEADING HOLOFERNES
c. 1619–20. Oil on canvas, 6'6-3/8" × 5'4" (1.99 × 1.63 m).

Galleria degli Uffizi, Florence. © Quattrone, Florence - courtesy of the Ministero Beni e Att. Culturali.

Painting (8 of 9)

- Cortona and Gaulli: Baroque Ceilings
 - Painters sought to portray an immeasurable heaven through using the viewpoint called *di sotto in sù*.
 - Pietro da Cortona's *The Glorification of the Papacy of Urban VIII* was structured around framing and mythological scenes.
 - The subject is an allegory of the virtues of the pope.



Pietro da Cortona THE GLORIFICATION OF THE PAPACY OF URBAN VIII
Ceiling in the Gran Salone, Palazzo Barberini, Rome. 1632–1639.
Fresco. Palazzo Barberini, Italy/Canali Photobank, Milan, Italy.

Painting (9 of 9)

- Cortona and Gaulli: Baroque Ceilings
 - Giovanni Battista Gaulli's *The Triumph of the Name of Jesus and the Fall of the Damned* fused sculpture and painting to eliminate any appearance of architectural division.
 - Every element builds the illusion that clouds and angels have descended into the top of the church during the Last Judgment.



Giovanni Battista Gaulli THE TRIUMPH OF THE NAME OF JESUS AND
FALL OF THE DAMNED
Vault of the church of Il Gesù, Rome. 1672–1685.
Fresco with stucco figures.
© Vincenzo Pirozzi, Rome.

Spain

- Spanish Habsburg kings Philip III, Philip IV, and Charles II reigned over a weakening empire.
 - Naples was in a constant state of unrest and the Netherlands gained independence in 1648.
 - Writers and artists produced great works despite the suffering of agriculture, industry, and trade.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (1 of 8)

- The primary influence on Spanish painting was Flanders in the fifteenth century, and Florence and Rome in the sixteenth century.
- Seventeenth-century painting was influenced by the drama of Caravaggio.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (2 of 8)

- Juan Sánchez Cotán
 - *Still Life with Quince, Cabbage, Melon, and Cucumber* contrasts curved shapes of the fruits and vegetables with angular geometry of the *cantarero*.
 - He was fascinated with spatial ambiguity and contemplative sensibility.



Juan Sánchez Cotán STILL LIFE WITH QUINCE, CABBAGE, MELON, AND CUCUMBER
c. 1602. Oil on canvas, 27-1/8" x 33-1/4" (68.8 x 84.4 cm).
San Diego Museum of Art. Gift of Anne R. and Amy Putnam. © akg-images/De Agostini Picture Lib.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (3 of 8)

- Jusepe de Ribera
 - Nicknamed "Lo Spagnoletto," he combined styles to create a new Neapolitan style.
 - The *Martyrdom of St. Bartholomew* captures the horror of the impending violence of being skinned alive.
 - Compression of figures into the foreground heightens the viewer's sense of witness to the scene.



Jusepe de Ribera MARTYRDOM OF ST. BARTHOLOMEW
1634. Oil on canvas, 41-1/4" x 44-7/8" (1.05 x 1.14 m).

National Gallery of Art, Washington, DC. Rosenwald Collection (1950.14.744). Image courtesy the National Gallery of Art, Washington.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (4 of 8)

- Francisco de Zurbarán
 - This artist emerged from the same Caravaggesque school of Seville as Velázquez.
 - *St. Serapion* is an arresting portrayal of a dead saint who sacrificed himself for the rescue of Christian captives.
 - The only colors are the red and gold of the insignia, making the portrait a tragic still life study of fabric and flesh.



Francisco de Zurbarán ST. SERAPION

1628. Oil on canvas, 47-1/2 x 40-3/4" (120.7 x 103.5 cm).

Wadsworth Atheneum, Hartford, Connecticut. Ella Gallup Sumner and Mary Catlin Sumner Collection Fund. Wadsworth Atheneum, Photo: Allen Phillips.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (5 of 8)

- Velázquez and Murillo
 - Diego Velázquez was one of the most brilliant painters of the age.
 - The model for *Water Carrier of Seville* was a well-known character in the city, symbolizing Velázquez's working from life and ordinary people.
 - He became official court painter to Philip IV until his death in 1660.



Diego Velázquez WATER CARRIER OF SEVILLE
c. 1619. Oil on canvas, 41-1/2" x 31-1/2" (105.3 x 80 cm).
Victoria & Albert Museum, London. V&A Images/Victoria and Albert Museum.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (6 of 8)

- Velázquez and Murillo
 - *The Surrender at Breda* was borne of Velázquez's studies in Italy.
 - The theme of triumph and conquest is removed from military propaganda.
 - The exchange seems gracious, resembling a courtly ideal.
 - Compositional virtuosity comes to the fore with controlled color and texture.



Diego Velázquez THE SURRENDER AT BRED (THE LANCES)

1634–1635. Oil on canvas, 10'-7/8" × 12'-1/2" (3.07 × 3.67 m).

Museo del Prado, Madrid. © 2016. Image Copyright Museo Nacional del Prado. © Photo MNP/Scala, Florence.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (7 of 8)

- Velázquez and Murillo
 - *Las Meninas* is an enormous multiple portrait featuring the king, queen, Infanta Margarita, maids of honor, and even the painter himself.
 - No consensus exists on the precise meaning of this painting other than royal portraiture; fundamentally, it is a personal artistic statement.



Diego Velázquez LAS MENINAS (THE MAIDS OF HONOR)
1656. Oil on canvas, 10'5" × 9'-1/2" (3.18 × 2.76 m).
Museo del Prado, Madrid. © 2016. Photo Scala, Florence.

Painting in Spain's Golden Age (8 of 8)

- Velázquez and Murillo
 - Seville declined after an outbreak of the plague in 1649, but art was still influenced by the work of Bartolomé Estebán Murillo, who focused on religious iconography.
 - *The Immaculate Conception* shows Mary dressed in blue and white according to Counter-Reformation instructions.



Bartolomé Esteban Murillo THE IMMACULATE CONCEPTION
c. 1660–1665. Oil on canvas, 81-1/8" x 56-5/8" (2.06 x 1.44 m).
Museo del Prado, Madrid. © 2016. Image Copyright Museo Nacional del Prado. © Photo MNP/Scala, Florence.

Architecture (1 of 2)

- Lavish decoration was once again embraced, opposing the sixteenth-century style of El Escorial.
- Ornamentation began to flood back into *retablos*, then portals, then finally entire buildings.

Architecture (2 of 2)

- The Cathedral of Santiago de Compostela
 - Popular saints challenged the role of St. James as patron saint of Spain.
 - Renewed interest in pilgrimages called for an elaborate façade to be added to the front of the Cathedral of St. James.
 - Its redesign focused on a wall of glass nicknamed "The Mirror."



WEST FAÇADE, CATHEDRAL OF ST. JAMES, SANTIAGO DE COMPOSTELA, SPAIN
South tower 1667–1680; north tower and central block finished mid 18th century by
Fernando de Casas y Nóvoas. © Bartosz Turek/Shutterstock.